



The invisible knot in the couple

What lies beneath the arguments that always repeat themselves.

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This ebook is a self-knowledge resource about couple dynamics. It does not replace therapeutic support or couples therapy. If your relationship involves violence, please seek specialized help.

1. The same argument, always

You know which one it is. I don't need to describe it, because you've lived it so many times that you know it by heart. The same triggers, the same words, the same tones of voice, the same looks, the same outcome. The setting changes, the pretext changes, but the structure is always the same. Like a play that repeats night after night, with the same actors, the same script, the same ending.

Maybe it's about the dishes. Or money. Or time. Or the children. Or sex. Or his family. Or your mother. The topic doesn't matter. What matters is that beneath the topic, there is something else. And that something else is the knot.

The invisible knot.

You know the mechanics well: he says something (or doesn't say, because sometimes silence is the most effective trigger). You feel something in your body: a tightening, a heat, an urge to shout or cry or leave. And you react. The same way you reacted last time. And the time before that. And the time before that.

There are variations, of course. Not all couples shout. There are couples who never raise their voices and who live in permanent conflict beneath the surface. Silent conflict: the looks that cut, the sighs that say "not again," the gestures of distance that speak louder than any shout. The "fine" that means "nothing is fine but I'm not going to waste energy explaining." The "whatever you want" that means "do what you want, I've stopped caring." That conflict is just as destructive as the other kind. Perhaps more so. Because it has none of the catharsis of an explosion. It accumulates. It rots. It corrodes from within, slowly, without anyone noticing.

And there are couples who alternate: periods of explosion followed by periods of icy silence followed by periods of apparent normality followed by a new explosion. The cycle repeats with the regularity of a tide. And each time the tide rises, both feel they've lost ground. That the relationship has grown more worn. That love has grown thinner. That patience has grown shorter.

And then comes the remorse. Or the coldness. Or two days of silence. Or a superficial reconciliation that resolves nothing but allows life to continue until the next time. Because there will be a next time. Both of them know there will.

And the most frustrating thing is that neither of them wants this. Neither wakes up in the morning thinking: "Today I'm going to ruin things again." Neither enters the argument with the intention of causing pain. But it happens. Always. As if there were an invisible force pulling them to the same place, the same conflict, the same wound, regardless of their will.

That invisible force is the knot.

And this book is about it. Not to untie it (that requires deeper, more accompanied, more guided work). But to see it. Because seeing the knot is the first step to stop being pulled by it.

If you could film all your arguments and watch them in a row, like episodes of a series, you'd be astonished not by the differences, but by the repetition. Because they're always the same. With different clothes, different pretexts, but the same plot. The same script. The same roles. And no matter how much you try to change your lines, no matter how much you promise "this time I won't react that way," the body does what the body knows: it reacts. The same way. Always.

And there is something particularly painful about repetition: the feeling of powerlessness. Of what's the use of trying. Of "this is who we are" and "this is who he is" and "this is who I am" and "this will never

change." That resignation may be the clearest symptom that the knot is working. Because the knot wants you to give up seeing it. It wants you to accept repetition as destiny. It wants you to look at the surface and never look beneath.

This book asks you to look beneath. Not to find blame. To find understanding. Because what you're going to see beneath the argument is not two villains. It's two people who love each other and who are trapped in patterns they didn't choose.

I know couples who have been arguing about the same thing for twenty years and never stopped to ask: why does this keep repeating? I know couples who have tried everything (couples therapy, books, workshops, vacations together, ultimatums, promises) and remain trapped in the same pattern. Not for lack of love. For lack of vision. Because the knot is invisible. It's beneath the surface. And as long as you don't see it, you can change everything on the surface and nothing changes beneath.

Maria and Pedro (fictional names, real story with altered details) have been arguing for twelve years about the same thing: he doesn't help around the house. She asks, he promises, he doesn't follow through. She explodes, he withdraws. She cries, he stays silent. She feels alone, he feels attacked. And then everything returns to the beginning.

On the surface, the problem is the division of tasks. But when we look deeper, we find something else. Maria grew up with a mother who did everything alone, who never asked for help, who sacrificed herself for the whole family, and who ended up bitter and exhausted. Maria swore she would never be like that. That her marriage would be different. That her husband would be a partner. And when Pedro doesn't help, it's not just the dishes that hurt her. It's the betrayal of a promise. It's the fear of becoming her mother. It's the panic of repeating what she swore she would never repeat.

And Pedro? Pedro grew up with a father who, when his mother complained, went silent. Who turned to stone. Who turned off the sound and waited for the storm to pass. Pedro learned, without anyone teaching him, that when a woman is angry, the best thing to do is disappear. Not out of malice. Out of survival. And every time Maria raises her voice, Pedro's body does what it learned: it closes. Shuts down. Waits.

And there is one particularly painful consequence of this displaced role-playing: the death of desire. When the woman becomes the husband's mother, or the husband becomes the wife's father, desire goes out. Not because the body stops working. Because desire lives in the tension between two separate beings who attract one another, not in the fusion of two beings who become confused. The mother doesn't desire the son.

The son doesn't desire the mother. And when the couple falls into this dynamic (she takes care of him, he depends on her, or vice versa), sexual attraction evaporates like water in the sun.

Many couples who come to me with the complaint "we no longer have desire" discover, when we look at the dynamic, that the desire didn't disappear. It was replaced by something else: care, dependence, protection, control. Things that look like love, and in a certain sense are love, but are not the same thing as desire. Desire needs healthy distance. It needs mystery. It needs two beings who meet as equals, not as father and daughter or mother and son. And recovering desire, often, means each person returning to their place: she stops being his mother, he stops being a child with her. And in the space that opens between them, desire can return.

This isn't simple. It isn't quick. And it isn't done without accompaniment. But it's possible. And it begins with vision: seeing where you are positioned in the relationship. Seeing what place you occupy. Asking yourself: am I in my place as a woman, or am I in the place of a mother?

Neither of them sees this. Maria sees a husband who doesn't help. Pedro sees a wife who shouts. But what is happening is something else: two family systems meeting, two inherited legacies colliding, two wounded

children inside two adults repeating the patterns they learned before they were old enough to question them.

This is the knot. And it's what we need to talk about.

But before going deeper, I want to tell you something: the fact that you have this repeated argument doesn't mean your marriage is doomed. On the contrary. Repetition is an invitation. It's the system telling you: "There is something here that needs to be seen." And the fact that you haven't left, that you keep trying, that you still care enough to get angry, is a sign that there is love. The opposite of love is not anger. It's indifference. As long as you get angry, you still care. And as long as you care, there is material to work with.

I know couples who gave up too early. Who saw the repetition and concluded: "It doesn't work. We're not compatible." And sometimes they were right. There are relationships that should not continue. There are toxic, destructive, violent relationships that need to end so that both can breathe. But there are many relationships that end not because they're impossible, but because no one taught the two people to look beneath. To see what is beneath the argument. To ask what the conflict really demands.

This book will not save your marriage. No book saves marriages. But it can open your eyes to something you have never seen. And when you see it, when you truly see it, everything changes. Not the argument (that may continue, at least for a while). But the way you live it. The way you interpret it. The way you react when it begins. Because you stop seeing an impossible husband and begin to see a wounded man repeating what he learned. And you stop seeing yourself as an exhausted woman and begin to see a woman reacting with inherited tools.

2. What they say it is, and what it really is

When a couple is in conflict, the first thing they do (alone or with help) is try to resolve the apparent problem. The division of tasks. The lack of communication. Money. Sex. And that makes sense: if there's a problem, you solve the problem. You negotiate. You make agreements. You stick charts on the refrigerator.

And sometimes it works. When the problem is genuinely practical (schedules, organization, logistics), practical solutions resolve it. But when the same argument comes back, week after week, month after month, year after year, despite all the agreements and all the charts, something more is at play. Something that can't be resolved by negotiation. Something that lives on a deeper layer.

Family Constellation teaches us that each person in a couple doesn't arrive alone. They arrive with their family. With their parents, their grandparents, their siblings. With all the dynamics, all the secrets, all the patterns they inherited. And when two people meet and love each other and build a life together, they are not just two: they are two entire systems meeting.

And these systems bring rules. Unwritten, unspoken, often unconscious rules. Rules about how one loves, how one argues, how one forgives, how one gives and receives. Your family had rules about conflict: did people shout in your house, or did they go quiet? In your family, was love shown in words or in actions? In your house, who was in charge? Who gave in? Who suffered in silence? Who exploded?

There is an experience almost all couples share that perfectly illustrates this meeting of systems: Christmas. Or any other family celebration. Notice: how do you celebrate Christmas in your family? With noise or silence? With many people or few? Do you start early or late? Are there gifts or not? What's the food? Who cooks? Who clears up? Who decides?

Now think about his family's Christmas. If it's different from yours (and most of the time it is), you'll understand that the Christmas conflicts so many couples have are not about the turkey or the in-laws. They're about two systems with different rules trying to occupy the same space. And neither gives in, because giving in seems like betraying their own family.

These rules are invisible. They aren't written anywhere. No one sat you down and said: "In our family, conflict is resolved this way." But you absorbed them like the air you breathed. Because children don't learn

from what they're told. They learn from what they see. From what they feel. From what the environment teaches them without words.

And his family had different rules. Or perhaps the same ones, but lived differently. And when the two sets of rules meet in the same room, at the same dinner table, in the same bed, what happens is what happens in any meeting between two systems with different rules: conflict.

But the conflict is not about the dishes. The conflict is about the rules. It's about what each person learned that love is, what love does, what love allows. And since those rules were learned so early, so deeply, so silently, neither of them is conscious of them. They act as if they were laws of nature. "That's how it's done." "That's what's normal." "Everyone knows that..."

But it's not how it's done. It's how it was done in your family. And how it was done in his. And the meeting of the two "how it's done" is where the knot forms.

Let me give you another example. Cláudia and Tomás argue about money. She thinks he spends too much. He thinks she controls too much. They seem to be two incompatible financial styles. But when we look at their families of origin, we find something else. Tomás's father went bankrupt when he was fourteen. The family lost everything. To-

más grew up with the feeling that money is dangerous, that it can disappear at any moment, and that therefore, while you have it, you should spend it. Enjoy it. Live. Because tomorrow it might not be there.

Cláudia, on the other hand, grew up with a mother who saved every cent, who lived in fear of not having enough, who never bought anything for herself. Cláudia inherited that fear. And she controls the money not out of stinginess, but out of terror. Out of an inherited anxiety that isn't even hers.

Tomás is not irresponsible. Cláudia is not controlling. They are two people reacting to two different family traumas, with tools they learned as children, without realizing they are using past solutions for present problems.

And this is what I mean when I talk about "what lies beneath." What they say it is (he spends too much, she controls too much) is not what it really is. What it really is: two family systems fighting against each other, using two adults as a battlefield.

Let me tell you one more story, because stories reach where explanations don't. Ricardo and Sara have been arguing for eight years about weekends. He wants to stay home, alone, in silence. She wants to go out,

see friends, do things. He says she never stops. She says he's a brick. Both feel misunderstood. Both feel rejected. And both think the other is the problem.

But Ricardo grew up in a house where chaos was constant. Parents who shouted, siblings who argued, neighbors knocking at the door. Silence was the only refuge he knew. When he stays home on the weekend, in silence, he is not rejecting Sara. He's taking care of himself in the only way he learned: by escaping noise.

Sara grew up in a house where her mother was depressed and spent weekends in bed, curtains drawn. The house was quiet, but in a way that frightened her. Silence, for Sara, is not peace. It's a signal of danger. It's a sign that someone is not well. And when Ricardo goes quiet, Sara's body goes into a panic. Not consciously. Her body reacts as it reacted as a child: she needs to go out, to move, to find noise, to have proof that the world is alive and that no one is disappearing.

When you look at Sara and Ricardo without this information, you see two incompatible lifestyles. When you look with this information, you see two children trying to survive with the tools they have. And suddenly, the argument about weekends is no longer about weekends. It's about safety. It's about emotional survival. It's about what each one needs in order to feel safe in the world.

And here is the cruel paradox of the couple: we choose partners who make us feel at home (because they activate the same patterns we know), and then we get furious when they behave exactly as we'd expect someone of that "type" to behave. Sara chose a quiet man because quietness was familiar to her (it was the emotional terrain of her childhood). And then she gets furious at his quietness. Ricardo chose an expressive woman because expressiveness was what he lacked. And then he feels suffocated by her expressiveness. Each chose the remedy and the poison in the same person.

This is not destiny. Not a curse. It's the unconscious trying to heal itself. Seeking the scenario where the original wound can be revisited, re-felt, and perhaps, with consciousness, rewritten. But without consciousness, without seeing, the scenario repeats itself indefinitely. Like a film stuck in a loop.

And the saddest part is that, while you don't see this, every argument seems to be about who is right. He thinks he's right (and by his criteria, he is). She thinks she's right (and by her criteria, she is). And each one fights to prove that their truth is The truth. But there isn't one truth. There are two truths, each shaped by a different family history. And neither is more valid than the other. They're simply different. And as long as each one fights to impose theirs, the relationship loses.

There are couples who spend decades in this war of being right. He's right about money. She's right about the children. He's right about organization. She's right about communication. And both are right. And both are trapped. Because being right has never saved a marriage. What saves marriages is not being right. It's being curious. Curious about the other, about their story, their fears, their wounds. And curious about your own story, your own fears, your own wounds. Because as long as you think the problem is the other person, you will never see the knot. The knot is between the two of you. It belongs to both of you. And it can only be seen when both of you stop fighting to be right and start asking: what are we really living here?

3. Giving and receiving: the invisible balance

There is a law that governs all human relationships, though we rarely speak of it. It's as old as love and as present as the air. Bert Hellinger, the therapist who systematized Family Constellations, called it the balance of giving and receiving.

The idea is simple in theory and complex in life: for a relationship to work, what one gives and the other receives needs to be in balance. Not a bookkeeping balance (I did this, you did that). But a felt balance. Each person needs to feel that they give and receive in similar measure. That the relationship is fair, not perfect, but fair.

When the balance breaks, the relationship suffers. And the balance breaks in two ways: when someone gives too much, or when someone receives too much. And, paradoxically, both are equally destructive.

The woman who gives too much (and she is perhaps the most common figure I encounter in the couples I accompany) feels generous, sacrificed, good. But what happens beneath is something else: by giving too much, she places the other in debt. And debt, when it accumulates, generates resentment. Not gratitude: resentment. Because no one wants to

live permanently in debt. No one wants to feel they can never repay enough. And so the other (the husband, usually) begins to withdraw. Not because he doesn't love. Because the debt is unbearable.

There is an image I often use to explain this dynamic: imagine a scale. On one side, what you give. On the other, what you receive. When the scale is balanced, there is flow. There is movement. There is life. When it tips (one side becomes too heavy), the flow stops. And the relationship stagnates.

Many women I know have the scale completely off-balance toward giving. They give everything: time, energy, attention, care, patience, body, soul. And receive little. Not because the other doesn't want to give. Often because they don't allow it. Because they don't know how to receive. Because they were trained to give, not to ask. Because "asking is weakness" and "needing is dependence" and "I can manage alone."

It's a dynamic I see repeatedly: the more she gives, the more he withdraws. And she interprets the withdrawal as "he doesn't love me," when in fact the withdrawal is his response to the weight of the debt. He doesn't know how to say: "Stop giving me so much, because I feel in debt and that's unbearable." He doesn't know because he's not conscious of it. He simply feels a vague discomfort, an irritation he can't explain, a wish to be alone that he himself doesn't understand.

And the woman who gives too much interprets that withdrawal as ingratitude. "I do everything for him and he doesn't appreciate it." But it's not that he doesn't appreciate. It's that he can't bear the weight of the debt. And the more she gives, the more he withdraws. And the more he withdraws, the more she gives. It's a perfect cycle of imbalance.

The opposite also exists: the woman who can't receive. Who refuses help, who refuses gifts, who refuses gestures of affection. Who says "you don't have to" and "I'll handle it" and "leave it." And beneath that refusal is, often, the fear of being in debt. The fear of depending. The fear that if she receives, she'll be vulnerable. But by not receiving, she prevents the other from giving. And the other, who needs to give in order to feel part of the relationship, feels useless. Excluded. Dispensable.

I know a woman who never let her husband help her with anything. She did everything: the house, the children, the shopping, the bills, the doctor's appointments, the school meetings. And she felt exhausted, alone, overloaded. But when he offered to help, she said: "Leave it, I'll do it." Not for control. Out of fear. Because in her family, receiving was dangerous. Her mother received from her father and her father used it as a bargaining chip: "I'm the one who pays for everything in this house,

you have no right to an opinion." Receiving meant losing power. Meant being in an inferior position. Meant owing. And the daughter learned: never depend. Never receive. Never be in debt.

And the husband, who was genuinely a man who wanted to participate, gradually withdrew. Not because he didn't want to. Because every time he tried, he was turned down. And repeated rejection teaches the body one thing: "You're not needed here." And when the body learns that, the desire to participate goes out. And the marriage turns into two people living in the same house but in separate worlds. They function as roommates with children in common. Efficient. Organized. And profoundly alone.

I want to mention one more aspect of giving and receiving that is rarely discussed: forgiveness. Forgiveness is, in a certain sense, the highest form of giving and receiving. When someone hurts you and you forgive, you are giving something. And when someone forgives you, you are receiving something. But forgiveness also obeys the balance. If you forgive always, without limits, without the other recognizing what they did, you are giving too much. And if you never forgive, never allow the account to be cleared, you are accumulating debt indefinitely.

Many couples live trapped in unforgiven hurts. Things that happened five, ten, twenty years ago and that were never truly resolved. They were pushed under the rug. They were "forgotten" (but no one forgets, the body remembers). And every new argument brings to the surface, subtly, all the previous hurts. Today's argument about the dishes carries the weight of the betrayal eight years ago, of the lack of support during pregnancy, of the cruel comment at Christmas 2019. Everything accumulates. And when it explodes, everything explodes at once.

The balance of giving and receiving is not an abstract concept. It's the backbone of every relationship. And when it's out of balance (and it is, in almost every couple I know, in one way or another), the relationship suffers. Not necessarily in a visible way. Sometimes it suffers in silence: in the absence of desire, in emotional distance, in loneliness for two, in the vague feeling that "something is missing" without being able to say what.

The balance of giving and receiving is not a balance sheet. It's a dance. A dance in which each person exposes a little, offers a little, receives a little. In which vulnerability is shared, not accumulated on one side. In which neither of them needs to be the hero, and neither needs to be the debtor.

And there is another imbalance, more subtle, that I see in many couples: the imbalance of suffering. When one of the two has suffered more (in childhood, in a previous life, in circumstances outside their control), the other tends to compensate. To erase themselves. To give space to the partner's suffering as if their own suffering didn't deserve space. "He had such a difficult childhood that I can't complain." "She's been through so much that I'm not going to burden her with my problems." And what seems like respect is, in fact, imbalance. Because when one doesn't bring their suffering into the relationship, the other is left alone with theirs. And loneliness within a couple is one of the most painful forms of loneliness.

Balance doesn't require both to have suffered equally. It requires both to have space to suffer. That both can be vulnerable. That neither has to be strong to compensate for the other's weakness. Because when one is always strong and the other always weak, there is no couple. There's a dynamic of caregiver and cared-for. And that dynamic kills desire, equality, and partnership.

And this balance, in most couples, is out of balance. Not out of malice. Out of inheritance. Because in her family, love meant sacrifice. And in his family, love meant protecting. And when sacrifice and protection meet, what it looks like is love, but what functions is imbalance.

4. Places and what each person brings from family

This is the central chapter of this book. Because this is where the knot becomes visible. Where you understand why the same argument keeps repeating. Where you can finally see what lies beneath.

In Family Constellations, we speak of "places." Every person in a family system has their place. Parents have the parents' place. Children have the children's place. The first child has the first's place, the second has the second's. And when someone is out of their place (when a child occupies the parent's place, when a mother occupies the daughter's place, when someone is excluded from the system), the entire system suffers.

In a couple, each partner brings their place from their family of origin. And often, the places they bring are incompatible with the place they need to occupy in the new family.

The woman who grew up as her own mother's mother (who took care of her mother emotionally, who was the confidante, the counselor, the one who held everything together) brings that pattern into the marriage: she becomes the husband's mother. She takes care of him, organizes him,

protects him, worries about him as though he were a child. And he, initially, accepts it. Because it's comfortable. Because someone is taking care of him. But over time, desire goes out. Because one doesn't desire one's own mother. And the relationship transforms into a functional, efficient one, but without passion. Without desire. Without that healthy tension that keeps the couple alive.

And she doesn't understand why. "I do everything for him. Why doesn't he want me anymore?" Because you're not his woman. You're his mother. And he doesn't see you as a partner. He sees you as a caregiver. And a caregiver is loved, but not desired.

The man who grew up with an absent father (physically or emotionally) brings a wound into the marriage: the wound of masculine absence. And that wound manifests in different ways. Some become absent, repeating the pattern. Others become hypercontrolling, compensating for the father's absence with excessive presence. Others become emotionally dependent, seeking in the woman the validation the father never gave. None of these responses is conscious. None is chosen. They are automatic reactions to a wound that was never treated.

And when the woman with the "mother of all" pattern joins the man with the "son without a father" pattern, what is created is a perfect dynamic of repetition. She takes care of him the way she took care of

her mother. He accepts the care the way he accepted (or wished for) the care of the father who never came. And both are living the wrong relationship: not the couple relationship, but the relationship with their parents.

And the argument about dishes, about money, about children, about sex, is only the surface. Beneath, what is being played out is the drama of the family of origin. And as long as that drama isn't seen, the argument repeats. Because it isn't an argument between two adults. It's an argument between two wounded children who found each other inside two adult bodies.

There's another pattern I see frequently: family secrets. When there is a secret in a family (a betrayal, an abortion, an illegitimate child, a bankruptcy, a hidden shame), that secret doesn't disappear by not being talked about. On the contrary: it gains weight. And the descendants, even without knowing the secret, live its effects. The distrust you feel in your marriage may not be yours. It may be the distrust your grandmother felt when she discovered your grandfather's betrayal, but never processed it. Your difficulty in surrendering may not be about your husband. It may be about an experience of betrayal or abandonment in your lineage that was never named.

And there is a pattern that deserves special attention, because it may be the most destructive of all: rescuing. The woman who chooses a "broken" man to fix him. Who falls in love with his potential, not with who he is. Who devotes the entire relationship to saving him: from depression, from drinking, from lack of ambition, from immaturity, from anger. And in that process of salvation, she loses herself.

This dynamic is not love. It's a repetition. In most cases, the woman who rescues in the relationship grew up rescuing in the family. She was the daughter who tried to save the alcoholic father. Or the depressed mother. Or the troubled brother. She learned that love is saving. That to love is to fix. That she is only loved when she is useful. And she takes this programming into marriage, choosing (unconsciously) partners who need saving.

And the man who allows himself to be rescued is also repeating. He's in the child's place, in the place of one who receives without giving, in the place of someone who never had to grow up because there was always someone doing it for him. And when the woman finally tires (and she does tire, because rescuing is exhausting and thankless), the man feels abandoned. "You promised you would take care of me." But she didn't promise. The wounded child inside her promised. And that promise should never have been made.

There is one thing I observe frequently in the couples who work with me: when someone changes place (when the woman who was the husband's mother stops being that, when the man who was a child in the relationship assumes his adult place), the relationship enters crisis. But it's a different kind of crisis. It's the reorganization crisis. The old patterns no longer work, the new ones aren't yet in place, and everything seems worse before it gets better. Many couples give up at this point. They think the change was a mistake, that it was better as it was, that at least before there was peace (even if it was a false peace, maintained at the cost of imbalance).

But if they endure the reorganization crisis, if they allow the new places to establish themselves, what emerges on the other side is a different relationship. Not perfect. But true. A relationship where two adults meet as equals, with their stories, with their wounds, but without unconsciously repeating the dramas of previous generations.

I'm not saying that every couple difficulty is inherited. There are conflicts that are genuinely of the present, that can be resolved with communication, compromise, emotional maturity. But when the conflict repeats despite every effort, when it has an intensity disproportionate to

the topic, when it seems to come from a deeper place than the situation justifies, it's worth asking: whose conflict is this? Is it mine? Is it ours? Or are we living something that belongs to another generation?

There are signals that can help you recognize when conflict is inherited. The first is disproportionality: the intensity of your reaction is much greater than the situation justifies. He forgot to call and you feel cosmic abandonment. She made a comment about your mother and you feel a consuming rage. When the reaction is disproportionate, it's almost certain it's not about the present. It's about the past. Something in the present activated a wound from the past, and you're reacting to the wound, not the situation.

The second signal is rigidity: you can't change your reaction, even when you want to. You know you shouldn't shout. You know you shouldn't shut down. You know you shouldn't say that phrase that destroys him. But you do it anyway. Because the reaction is automatic, comes from a place so deep that conscious will can't reach it. And that rigidity is a sign of inherited pattern. Not lack of character. Family programming.

The third signal is familiarity: you feel you've lived this before. Not in this relationship. In another life. In your childhood. In your parents' house. In the way they treated each other. And when you notice you're

reproducing a film you've already seen, when the argument sounds strangely familiar, it's because you're repeating. And repetition is always an invitation to look backward.

5. When each person's past enters the relationship

If the previous chapter talked about the patterns we bring, this one talks about the moment when those patterns are activated. Because there is a difference between carrying a pattern and living it. And the couple relationship is, perhaps, the place where patterns most easily activate.

Why? Because intimacy is the most vulnerable territory there is. When you open yourself to someone, when you surrender, when you lower your defenses, everything that was stored comes to the surface. Old wounds, old fears, unfulfilled expectations, broken promises. Intimacy doesn't create the wounds. It reveals them.

And that's why so many couples say: "At the beginning everything was so good. What happened?" What happened was intimacy. At the beginning, when the relationship is new, the defenses are high. We show our best version. We control. We compensate. We enchant. But with time, as intimacy grows, defenses lower. And what appears beneath the defenses is the raw material: fears, needs, automatic reactions, inherited patterns.

And there is one particular moment when everything intensifies: when children arrive. Because children immediately and brutally activate all the parental patterns each person carries. The way you were cared for (or not cared for) by your mother appears immediately in the way you care for your children. The way your partner was treated by his father appears immediately in the way he relates to your children. And suddenly, the couple who seemed to be functioning well begins to have conflicts that neither of them understand. Because they're no longer just two. They're two with their children, with their parents, with the ghosts of all the generations that came before.

Teresa and André had a marriage she described as "good enough." They communicated. They respected each other. They'd built a stable life. And then their first daughter was born. And everything changed. André became distant. He worked more, came home later, shut himself away. Teresa felt abandoned. She shouted. She cried. She accused him of not being a partner. He responded with silence. She felt like her mother: alone raising the children while the husband disappeared.

And that was exactly what was happening. Not because André was like Teresa's father. But because Teresa was seeing her father in André. She was reacting to the past, not the present. And André, who in turn had a

father who would become invisible when emotions grew too intense, was repeating exactly his father's pattern: disappearing when the emotional storm becomes unbearable.

Neither of them saw this. Each only saw their own pain, their own frustration, their own version of the story. And each was right, in their perspective. But each perspective was limited. Because it didn't include what they couldn't see: the past living in the present.

And there is one more thing I need to mention about the past in the relationship: the way each person deals with vulnerability. Vulnerability is the currency of intimacy. Without vulnerability, there is no depth. Without vulnerability, the relationship stays on the surface: functional, organized, but empty. The problem is that vulnerability, for many people, is the most frightening thing in the world. Because being vulnerable with someone is giving them power. It's showing them where it hurts. It's trusting that the other won't use your weakness against you.

And that trust (or the lack of it) comes from very far back. From the first relationship of vulnerability you had: with your parents. If when you were vulnerable (when you cried, when you were afraid, when you asked for help), the response was care and presence, you learned that vulnerability is safe. But if the response was rejection ("stop crying"),

ridicule ("don't be a baby"), punishment, or simply absence, you learned that vulnerability is dangerous. And you carry that lesson into all your relationships.

The man who closes himself when there is conflict may not be being cold. He may be protecting himself. Because in his childhood, showing emotion was dangerous. The woman who shouts may not be being aggressive. She may be desperate to be heard. Because in her childhood, the only way to be noticed was to make noise.

And when these two reactions meet (his silence against her shouting, or his shouting against her silence), what is created is a circular dance of pain. He closes because she shouts. She shouts because he closes. And neither can stop, because the reaction is faster than consciousness.

And there is another moment when the past enters the relationship with force: in crises. When one of them loses their job, when someone falls ill, when a family member dies, when there is a change of city, of house, of lifestyle. In those moments of vulnerability, defenses drop completely. And what appears is not the competent adult who knows how to handle the situation. It's the child. The child who learned that crises are faced in a certain way (fleeing, fighting, going quiet, controlling, collapsing). And when the two children meet in the middle of a crisis, chaos sets in.

The most difficult moment in a marriage is not routine (though routine wears things down). It's crisis. Because crisis is when all the disguises fall. All the effort both make in daily life to be "adults," to be "reasonable," to "not repeat the parents' mistakes," all that effort collapses when the pressure is too great. And what remains is the raw material: old fears, old wounds, automatic reactions that come from so far back they can't even remember having been learned.

If you've been through a crisis in your relationship, you know what I'm talking about. That moment when you look at your partner and don't recognize him. When he says something and you think: "Who is this person?" But the more useful question, however difficult, is another: "What child is he being in this moment? And what child am I being?"

Not to justify. Not to excuse. To understand. Because understanding is the beginning of everything.

And there is one last aspect about the past in the relationship that I need to mention: former relationships. In Family Constellations, all previous partners belong to the system. If your partner had a previous relationship (especially if that relationship produced children), that person is part of the system. Not as a rival. As a member. And when a former partner is excluded (not mentioned, not recognized, treated as if they didn't exist), the system reacts. Often, it's one of the children who "re-

presents" the excluded, adopting behaviors no one understands. Or it's the relationship itself that suffers, as if there were a ghost in the room that no one names.

Recognizing that there was someone who came before is not a threat to your place. It's the opposite: it's what allows your place to remain secure. Because when all who belong to the system are recognized, the system calms. And when the system calms, conflicts that seemed unsolvable begin to loosen.

This applies to your former partners too, if you had any. Recognizing them internally (not as mistakes, not as regrets, but as people who were part of your story) is an act of integration that benefits your current relationship. Because as long as there are parts of your history you refuse, those parts exert pressure. And pressure manifests where you least expect it: in the present.

6. Seeing the knot

If you've made it this far, you may be recognizing patterns in your relationship that you've never named. You may be seeing, for the first time, that the argument about dishes was never about dishes. That your partner's distance may not be indifference, but an inherited reaction. That your anger may not be about what he did yesterday, but about what someone did two generations ago.

Seeing is the first step. And it's enormous. Because when you see the knot, when you recognize it, when you name it, something changes. It doesn't disappear. But it stops being invisible. And what is visible can be worked on. What is invisible controls you.

But I want to be honest with you: seeing the knot is not the same as untying it. Seeing gives you awareness. Untying requires work. Work that, in most cases, isn't done alone. Nor only as a couple. It's done with accompaniment. It's done with someone who knows family systems, who can read the patterns, who can guide you (and guide you both) in the process of returning to each system what belongs to it.

SyncHim was created for that. For couples who want to go beyond the surface. For couples who have realized that the usual tools (communication, negotiation, compromise) aren't enough when the knot is deeper than the present. Find SyncHim at synchim.viviannedossantos.com.

And if you feel that the work you need to do begins with yourself (with your inheritance, with your patterns, with what you bring from your family), FreeMe may be the starting point. Because before looking at the couple's knot, it's often necessary to look at the knot you carry alone. At freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

I won't tell you that your marriage will improve if you read this book. I can't promise that. What I can tell you is that you will leave these pages seeing what was previously invisible. And that vision, in itself, already changes something. Because the next time the same argument begins (and it will begin, because patterns don't disappear by being seen, they only lose some of their power), perhaps you'll manage to pause for a moment. Perhaps you'll manage to ask yourself: "What is really happening here? Whose pain is this? What is each of us bringing from home?"

And in that pause, in that question, something new can be born. Not the solution. But the space where the solution becomes possible.

And I want to end with something that may seem strange but that is true: your partner, with all his flaws, his patterns, his reactions that drive you mad, was the person your system chose. Not by chance. Not by bad luck. Because he touches exactly your wounds. Because he activates exactly your patterns. Because he forces you to look at what you've never looked at. This isn't romantic destiny. It's the intelligence of the system. Family Constellations show us that we choose (unconsciously) partners who touch our wounds because the psyche wants to heal. Not by sabotaging us. By showing us. Your partner is a mirror of your patterns. And you are a mirror of his. And the conflict that arises between you is the place where the mirrors meet. Is it uncomfortable? Enormously. But it's also the place where truth lives.

There is a phrase I often hear in constellations: "I see you." It seems simple. Three words. But when said with truth, when you look at your partner and truly see him (not the version you want him to be, not the projection you place on him, not the role you've assigned him, but him, whole, with his story, with his wounds, with his fears), something transforms. Not magically. But really.

Because being seen is the thing we all most want and most fear. And when two human beings truly see each other, beyond the roles, beyond the defenses, beyond the inheritances, the knot begins to loosen. Not

because it disappears. Because it no longer needs to be so tight.

And there is something I want to say specifically about the woman's role in all of this. Because most people who read books about relationships, who seek therapy, who try to understand what's happening in the marriage, are women. Men, in most cases, resist more. And the temptation is to think: "If he doesn't want to work on this, there's nothing to be done."

But it's not quite like that. Constellations show us that when one element of the system changes, the whole system reorganizes. You don't need to wait for him to change. You can change. Not in the sense of adapting more, giving in more, enduring more (you already do that in excess). In the sense of stepping out of your pattern. Of stopping reacting automatically. Of pausing when the impulse comes. Of asking, instead of accusing. Of looking at your inheritance before looking at his flaw.

When a woman does this internal work (not to save the marriage, but to free herself from the patterns that trap her), something happens in the relationship. Not by magic. By systemic dynamics. When you change place, the other is forced to reposition themselves. They may resist, may protest, may feel uncomfortable. But the change has already begun. And once begun, it doesn't stop. Couples that form tend to form around un-

conscious complementarities: what he brings fits what you lack, and vice versa. And the conflicts that arise are not accidents. They're opportunities for growth disguised as problems.

I'm not romanticizing conflict. I'm not saying you should stay in a relationship that destroys you just because "it's an opportunity for growth." If the relationship is harming you, if there is abuse, if there is violence, leave. Protect yourself. But if the relationship is difficult (and almost all are, in some way), if there is love but there are patterns, if there is will but there is repetition, then perhaps the path isn't flight. Perhaps the path is looking at the knot. Seeing it. Naming it. And, with help, beginning to untie it.

Not alone. Not by force. With understanding. With presence. With the humility to recognize that each of you brings a story, and that it's in that story that the knot lives.

With care, *Vivianne*

This material is for self-knowledge and reflection on relational dynamics. It does not constitute therapeutic, psychological, or couples therapy advice. If your relationship involves violence or abuse, seek

specialized help. If you feel you need professional support for your relationship, seek a qualified couples therapist. Seeing the patterns is the first step. Transforming them is done with support.

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